A problem brief you can challenge

Separate the observation, explanation and proposed response.

01 Name the difficult decision.

02 Keep evidence and explanation in separate columns.

03 Record the observed event.

04 Set boundaries that protect the decision.

05 Write the constraints and dependencies.

06 Write a brief someone can disagree with.

07 Agree the test and next commitment.

Name the difficult decision.

Hypothetical example: an operations lead is assigning a request to a team. They need to know who can accept it now.

Person and situation

Who is making the decision, and what changed?

Current obstruction

Which information or step prevents the person from finishing?

Keep evidence and explanation in separate columns.

A workaround can reveal a missing piece of information. It does not yet tell you which interface should provide it.

Recorded evidence	Current explanation	Still to check
The lead messages team owners before assigning a request.	The product does not show current capacity.	Does capacity change too quickly to publish?
The lead keeps a separate team list.	Team ownership is hard to find.	Does the list contain rules the product lacks?

Record the observed event.

A useful record names the situation and action before adding the team's explanation.

Event and action

What did the person actually do?

Source and date

Where can someone inspect the evidence?

Missing information

What do we still need to learn about this event?

Set boundaries that protect the decision.

A useful boundary tells the designer which assumptions are settled and which can still be challenged.

WITHIN THIS WORK

Assignment and team availability

Review the information a lead uses to choose a team.

OUTSIDE THIS WORK

Changing staffing policy

Record the dependency if the assignment problem cannot be solved without it.

Write the constraints and dependencies.

A boundary should explain why it exists, so the team knows when another discussion is necessary.

Fixed constraint

Which rule or condition must the work respect?

Open choice

Which decision can this work still change?

Dependency owner

Who can resolve a condition outside this work?

Write a brief someone can disagree with.

Example brief: help a lead see which team can accept this type of request before assignment.

Open question: can availability be maintained accurately enough to support the decision?

Problem statement

Describe the person, task and observed obstruction.

Alternative cause

What else might explain the same observation?

First check

What would distinguish the two explanations?

Agree the test and next commitment.

Choose a check that could make the team revise its preferred explanation.

Next check

What can we observe or compare?

Decision condition

Which result would favour a different explanation?

Owner and review point

Who will inspect the evidence before choosing the response?